



Coimisiún na Scrúduithe Stáit State Examinations Commission

LEAVING CERTIFICATE EXAMINATION, 2025

English - Higher Level - Paper 2

Total Marks: 200

Duration: 3 hours 20 minutes

Candidates must attempt the following:

- ONE Question from SECTION I – The Single Text
- ONE Question from SECTION II – The Comparative Study
- ONE question on the Unseen Poem from SECTION III – Poetry
- ONE Question on Prescribed Poetry from SECTION III – Poetry

N.B. Candidates must answer on Shakespearean Drama.

They may do so in Section I, The Single Text (King Lear) or in Section II, The Comparative Study (King Lear, The Merry Wives of Windsor)

INDEX OF SINGLE TEXTS

<i>The Tenant of Wildfell Hall</i>	Page - 2
<i>All the Light We Cannot See</i>	Page - 2
<i>The Crucible</i>	Page - 2
<i>King Lear</i>	Page - 3
<i>Frankenstein</i>	Page - 3

This document must be handed up at the end of the examination.

SECTION I

THE SINGLE TEXT

(60 marks)

Candidates must answer **one** question from this section (A – E).

A THE TENANT OF WILDFELL HALL - Anne Brontë

- (i) “Despite the multiple conflicts, both personal and societal, explored by Brontë in *The Tenant of Wildfell Hall*, the reader is left with a strong sense of hope.” To what extent do you agree with this statement? Develop your response with reference to the text.

OR

- (ii) “Brontë uses keenly-observed moments skilfully in her novel, *The Tenant of Wildfell Hall*, to illuminate a variety of profoundly human qualities in her characters.” Discuss this view developing your response with reference to the text.

B ALL THE LIGHT WE CANNOT SEE – Anthony Doerr

- (i) “Despite the multiple conflicts, both personal and societal, explored by Doerr in *All the Light We Cannot See*, the reader is left with a strong sense of hope.” To what extent do you agree with this statement? Develop your response with reference to the text.

OR

- (ii) “Doerr uses keenly-observed moments skilfully in his novel, *All the Light We Cannot See*, to illuminate a variety of profoundly human qualities in his characters.” Discuss this view developing your response with reference to the text.

C THE CRUCIBLE – Arthur Miller

- (i) “While we are intrigued by the immediate consequences of Abigail’s actions, in Miller’s play, *The Crucible*, it is the extent to which these actions expose the strengths and weaknesses of the people of Salem that is really captivating for the audience.” Discuss this view developing your response with reference to the text.

OR

- (ii) “Miller’s play, *The Crucible*, contains tension-filled moments that are simultaneously discomforting yet also profoundly human.” Discuss this view developing your response with reference to the text.

D KING LEAR – William Shakespeare

- (i) “The speed with which the world in *King Lear* falls apart, after Lear’s abdication, makes us consider whether, due to a variety of factors, it would have descended into chaos anyway, had he not given his kingdom away.”
To what extent do you agree with this view? Develop your response with reference to the text.

OR

- (ii) “Shakespeare’s play, *King Lear*, contains bewildering moments that are simultaneously discomfoting yet also profoundly human.” Discuss this view developing your response with reference to the text.

E FRANKENSTEIN – Mary Shelley

- (i) “Despite the multiple conflicts, both personal and societal, explored by Shelley in *Frankenstein*, the reader is left with a strong sense of hope.”
To what extent do you agree with this statement? Develop your response with reference to the text.

OR

- (ii) “Shelley uses keenly-observed moments skilfully in her novel, *Frankenstein*, to illuminate a variety of profoundly human qualities in her characters.”
Discuss this view supporting your response with reference to the text.

SECTION II THE COMPARATIVE STUDY (70 marks)

Candidates must answer **one** question from **either A** – Theme or Issue **or B** – Cultural Context **or C** – General Vision and Viewpoint.

In your answer you may not use the text you have answered on in **SECTION I** – The Single Text.

All texts used in this section must be prescribed for comparative study for this year's examination. Candidates may refer to only one film in the course of their answers.

Please note:

- Questions in this section use the word **text** to refer to all the different kinds of texts available for study on this course.
- When used, the word **reader** includes viewers of films and theatre audiences.
- When used, the term **technique** is understood to include techniques employed by all writers and directors of films.
- When used, the word **author** is understood to include all writers and directors of films.
- When used, the word **character** is understood to refer to both real people and fictional characters in texts.
- When used, the words **narrative** or **story** are understood to refer to both real life and fictional texts.

A THEME OR ISSUE

1. (a) Discuss how, by thoroughly investigating a theme or issue in **one** text on your comparative study, the author of this text exposed both positive and negative dimensions to that theme or issue.
Develop your response with reference to your chosen text. (30)
- (b) In each of **two other** texts on your comparative course compare how, by thoroughly investigating the same theme or issue discussed in part 1 (a), the authors of these texts, exposed both positive and negative dimensions to that theme or issue.
Develop your response with reference to your chosen texts. (40)

OR

2. Compare how the complexity of **one** character, from **at least two** comparative texts you have studied, was determined by the depth to which the authors explored a particular theme or issue in these texts. Clearly identify the theme or issue you have chosen to discuss. Develop your response with reference to your chosen texts. (70)

B CULTURAL CONTEXT

1. (a) In the case of **one** text on your comparative course, explain how a significant character's engagement with aspects of the cultural context in that text did or did not help to build resilience in that character. Develop your response with reference to the text. (30)
- (b) In the case of **two other** texts on your comparative course, compare how a significant character's engagement with aspects of the cultural contexts in each of these texts did or did not help to build resilience in each of these characters. Develop your response with reference to your chosen texts. (40)

OR

2. In the case of **at least two texts** on your comparative course, compare the extent to which key characters in each of these texts, shape or are shaped by, or both, the cultural contexts which they inhabit. Develop your response with reference to your chosen texts. (70)

C GENERAL VISION AND VIEWPOINT

1. (a) In the case of **one** text on your comparative course, use one or more key moment(s), to explain whether complex or simple factors or both, in your chosen text, helped you to form your sense of the general vision and viewpoint of that text. Develop your response with reference to the text. (30)
- (b) Using one or more key moment(s) in each of **two other** texts on your comparative course, compare the extent to which it was complex or simple factors or both, in your chosen texts, that helped you to form your sense of the general vision and viewpoint of these texts. Develop your response with reference to your chosen texts. (40)

OR

2. In the case of **at least two** texts on your comparative course, compare how your general vision and viewpoint of these texts was influenced by the extent to which characters avail of opportunities to learn and improve, when they encounter them. Develop your response with reference to your chosen texts. (70)

SECTION III

POETRY

(70 marks)

Candidates must answer **A** – Unseen Poem **and** **B** – Prescribed Poetry.

A UNSEEN POEM (20 marks)

Read the following poem, and answer **either** Question **1** **or** Question **2** which follow.

The Word

I couldn't tell you now what possessed me
to shut summer out and stay in my room.
Or at least to attempt to. In bed mostly.
It's my dad, standing in the door frame
not entering – but pausing to shape advice
that keeps coming back. 'Whatever is matter,

must *enjoy the life*.' He pronounced this twice.
And me, I heard wrongness in putting a *the*

Before *life*. In two minds. Ashamed. Aware.
That I knew better, though was stuck inside
while the sun was out. That I'm native here.
In a halfway house. Like that sticking word.
That definite article, half right, half
wrong, still present between *enjoy* and *life*.

Zaffar Kunial

1. (a) Why do you think Kunial has called this poem 'The Word'? Support your answer with reference to the poem. (10)
- (b) "Kunial uses language in 'The Word' in a highly skilful way." To what extent do you agree with this statement? Support your response with reference to the poem. (10)

OR

2. "Kunial reveals many fascinating insights into human nature and human relationships in his poem, 'The Word'."
Discuss this view, supporting your response with reference to the poem. (20)

B PRESCRIBED POETRY (50 marks)

1. Tracy K Smith

“Assisted by an appreciation of style, a reader can discover universal truths in Smith’s poetry, while exploring specific aspects of everyday life.”

Discuss this statement with reference to both the themes and language found in the poetry by Tracy K Smith on your Leaving Certificate English course.

2. Patrick Kavanagh

“Kavanagh’s poetry can be unfamiliar to contemporary readers, who struggle to appreciate the lyrical energy in the poet’s work.”

Discuss the extent to which you agree or disagree with the above statement, developing your discussion with reference to both the themes and language found in the poetry by Patrick Kavanagh on your Leaving Certificate English course.

3. Derek Mahon

“Mahon paints masterly portraits of conflicted characters and complex places, using words like skilful brushstrokes.”

Discuss this statement with reference to both the themes and language found in the poetry by Derek Mahon on your Leaving Certificate English course.

4. Gerard Manley Hopkins

“Hopkins interrogates positive and negative aspects of spirituality, using language in both conventional and experimental ways in his poetry.”

Discuss this statement with reference to both the themes and language found in the poetry by Gerard Manley Hopkins on your Leaving Certificate English course.

5. Emily Dickinson

“Dickinson exploits a darkly humorous and playful style, to explore profound themes in her poetry.”

Discuss the extent to which you agree or disagree with the above statement, developing your discussion with reference to both the themes and language found in the poetry by Emily Dickinson on your Leaving Certificate English course.

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Leaving Certificate – Higher Level

English

3 hours and 20 minutes